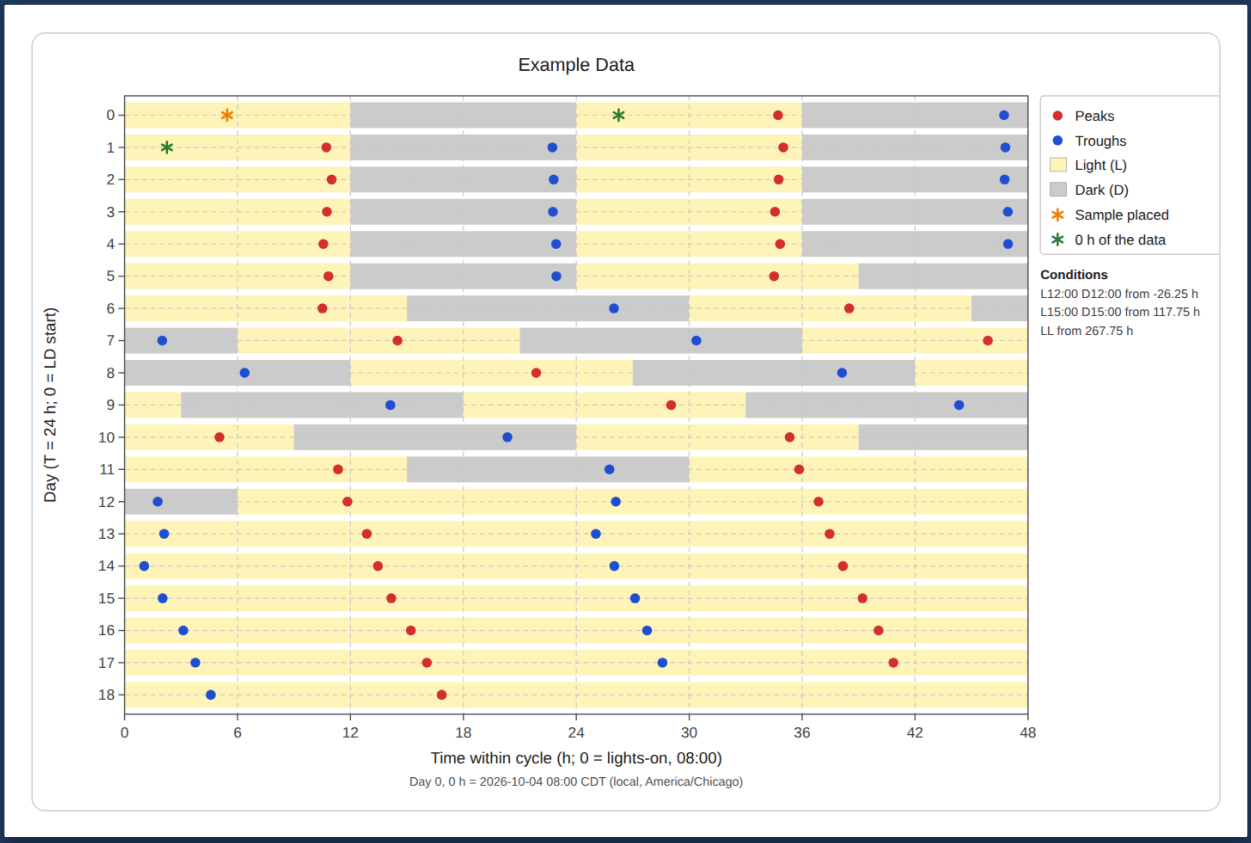
Actogram Plotter

User Manual · Web version

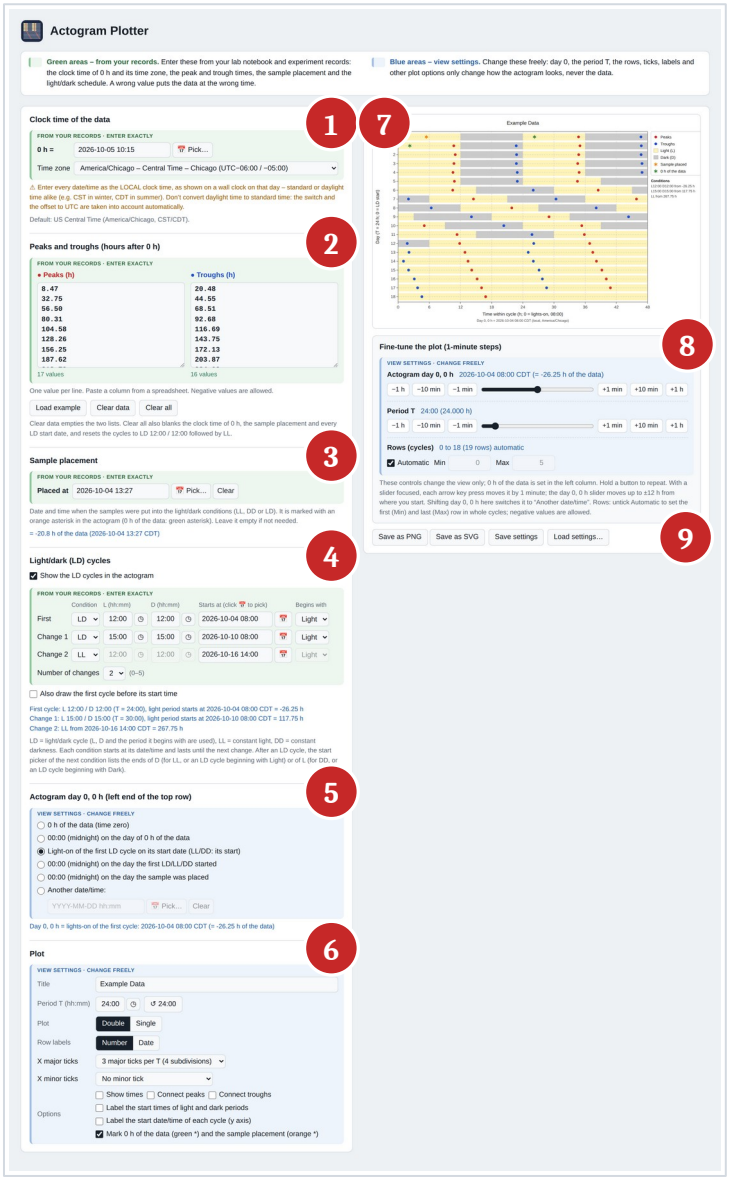
Draws an actogram from the peak and trough times of a circadian time series, such as a bioluminescence rhythm recorded with JKtron or Ttron, together with the light/dark schedule of the experiment.

Open the app: https://dxda6216.github.io/actogram_plotter/



Runs in any current desktop browser · No installation · Your data stays in your browser

Screen overview



1 **Clock time of the data** date and time of 0 h, time zone

2 **Peaks and troughs** paste the times; example, clear

3 **Sample placement** when the samples went into the conditions

4 **Light/dark (LD) cycles** the LD, LL and DD schedule

5 **Actogram day 0, 0 h** left end of the top row

6 **Plot** period T, ticks, labels, options

7 **Actogram** the figure, updated as you type

8 **Fine-tune the plot** 1-minute adjustments, rows

9 **Save buttons** PNG, SVG and settings files

Green and blue areas

Green areas – from your records. Enter these from your lab notebook and experiment records: the clock time of 0 h and its time zone, the peak and trough times, the sample placement and the light/dark schedule. A wrong value puts the data at the wrong time.

Blue areas – view settings. Change these freely: day 0, the period T, the rows, ticks, labels and other plot options only change how the actogram looks, never the data.

The settings column and the fine-tune panel are tinted in two colours. They tell you which values must come from your experiment records and which you can change as you like.

Green – from your records

Enter exactly, from the lab notebook

- Clock time of the data: 0 h and the time zone
- Peaks and troughs (hours after 0 h)
- Sample placement: placed at
- Light/dark (LD) cycles: conditions, L, D, start dates and times, begins with, number of changes

A wrong value puts the data, the lighting or the asterisks at the wrong time. Check these against your records before you save a figure.

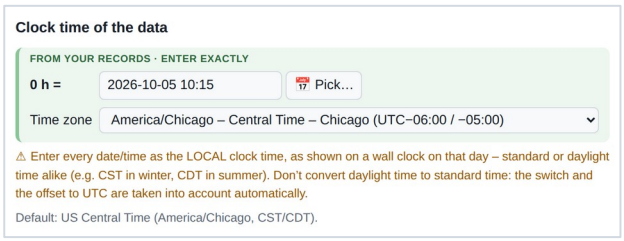
Blue – view settings

Change freely

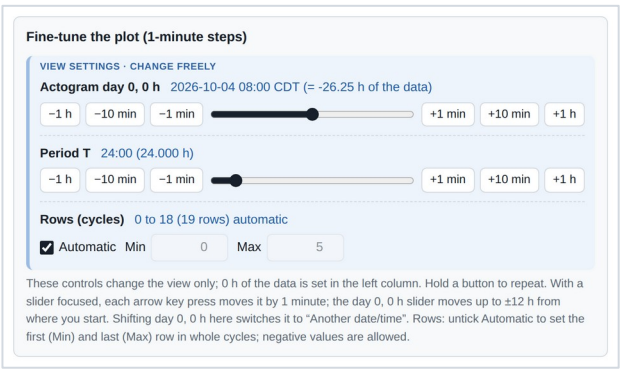
- Actogram day 0, 0 h
- Plot: title, period T, double or single plot, row labels, ticks and options
- Fine-tune panel: day 0, period T and rows

These only change how the actogram looks; the data and the schedule stay the same. Try different settings as often as you like.

0 h of the data is a recorded value, so it is set only in the left column, under Clock time of the data. The fine-tune panel changes view settings only.



A green area: Clock time of the data



A blue area: the fine-tune panel

» Quick start

Before you start: open the app. It starts with example data (title “Example Data”). Click **Clear all** to start a new experiment. Steps 1–4 (green areas) come from your records; steps 5–8 (blue) only change the view.

1 **Set the clock time of 0 h**
Pick the local date and time that corresponds to 0.00 h of your data. Keep the time zone at US Central Time unless the experiment ran elsewhere.

2 **Paste peaks and troughs**
Paste the peak times and the trough times (hours after 0 h) into the two lists, one value per line.

3 **Enter the sample placement**
Pick when the samples were put into the light/dark conditions (optional; shown as an orange asterisk).

4 **Enter the light/dark schedule**
Describe the first condition (LD, LL or DD) and up to five changes, each with its start date and time.

5 **Choose actogram day 0, 0 h**
Usually “lights-on of the first LD cycle”, so the horizontal axis counts hours from lights-on.

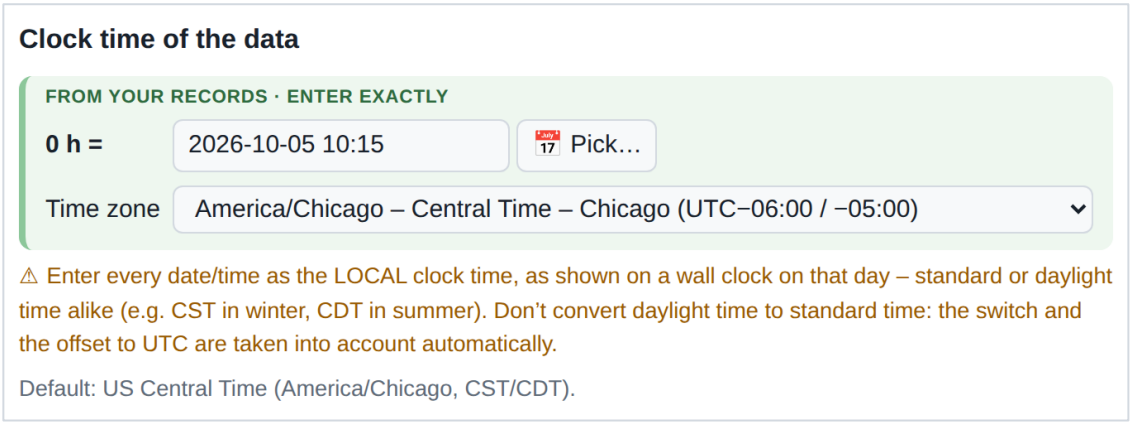
6 **Set the plot**
Set period T (24:00 for a 24-h day) and the display options: ticks, labels, title.

7 **Check the actogram**
The figure redraws after every change. Red points are peaks, blue points troughs; green and orange asterisks mark 0 h and the placement.

8 **Fine-tune if needed**
Shift day 0 or T in 1-minute steps, or choose which rows (cycles) are shown.

9 **Save**
Save the figure as PNG or SVG, and your inputs as a settings file to reload later.

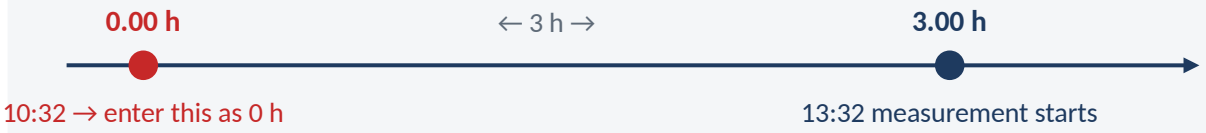
1 Clock time of the data



0 h = is the local date and time that corresponds to 0.00 h of your time-series data. Every peak and trough time is counted from this moment.

- **Data that start at 0.00 h** (the usual JKtron/Ttron output): enter the date and time when the measurement began.
- **Data whose first point is not 0.00 h:** subtract the time of the first data point from the date and time it was recorded.

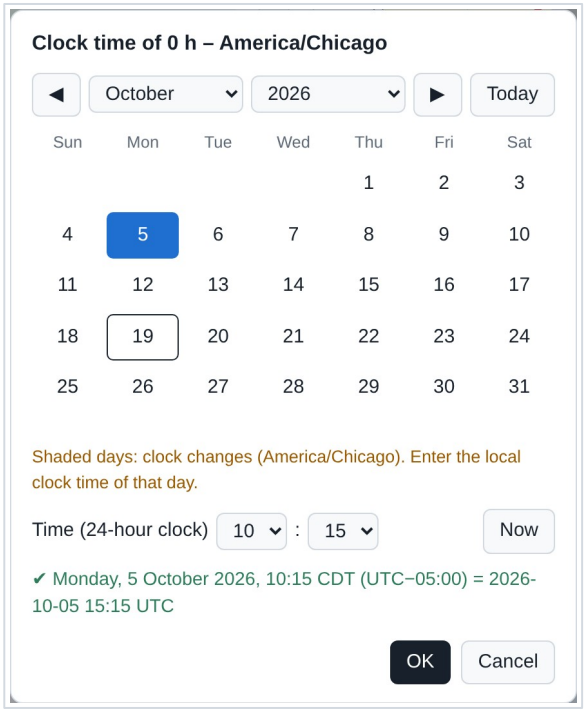
Example. The measurement began on 18 October 2026 at 13:32 (1:32 PM), and the first data point is labelled 3.00 h. Then 0 h = 13:32 − 3:00 = 10:32: click **Pick...** and select **2026-10-18 10:32**.



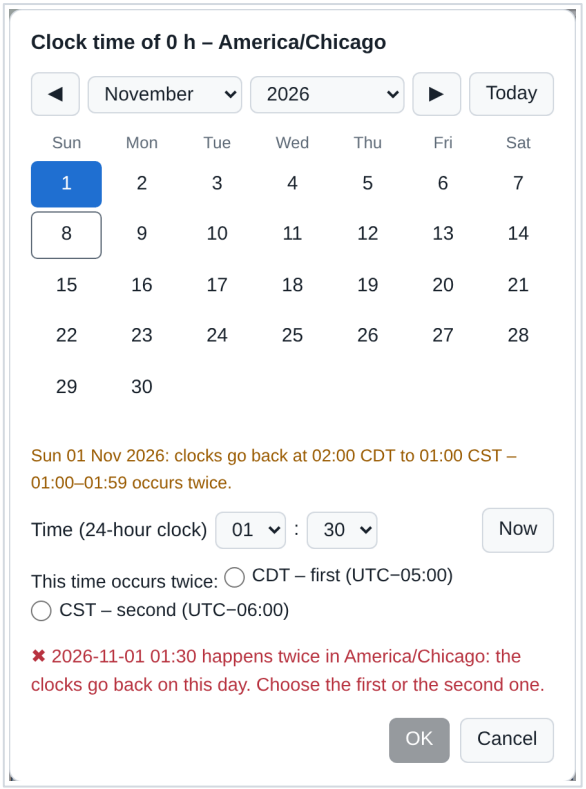
Time zone. Normally leave it at the default, US Central Time (America/Chicago). Change it only if the clock of the experiment ran in another zone; the list runs from east to west, with UTC last, and "Other..." accepts any zone name or an offset such as UTC+09:00.

Enter local clock times. Type every date and time as the wall clock showed it that day, CST in winter or CDT in summer. Do not convert daylight time: the app converts to UTC itself, so intervals across a daylight-saving change get their true length.

1 Using the date and time picker



An ordinary day



The day the clocks go back (1 Nov 2026)

- **Open:** click the date field or **Pick...** (📅 in the LD table).
- **Date:** choose the month and year from the lists or with the arrow buttons, then click the day. **Today** jumps to today.
- **Time:** choose the hour and minute (24-hour clock); the mouse wheel over a list also changes it. **Now** sets the current date and time.
- **Check:** the green line shows the weekday, the local time with its zone abbreviation, the offset and the time in UTC. **OK** works only when the line is green.
- **Shaded days** are days on which the clocks change. A time in the skipped hour (March) is refused. For a time in the repeated hour (November, 01:00–01:59) choose the first (CDT) or the second (CST) occurrence; it is saved as, for example, “2026-11-01 01:30 CST”.

2 Peaks and troughs

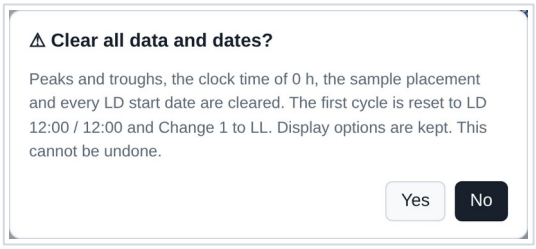


- Paste the **peak times** into the left list and the **trough times** into the right list, one value per line, in hours after 0 h (for example 12.47).
- Copy a column from Excel or from the output of your rhythm-analysis software and paste it with Ctrl+V. Commas, tabs and spaces also separate values. Negative values are plotted before 0 h.
- Under each list the app shows how many values it read (green) or which items are not numbers (red). Remove units or text, and use a decimal point.
- The two lists are independent: they may hold different numbers of values, in any order.
- The app does no rhythm analysis; it plots the times you enter.

Load example replaces the data, the dates and the LD cycles with the example data set. Display options are kept.

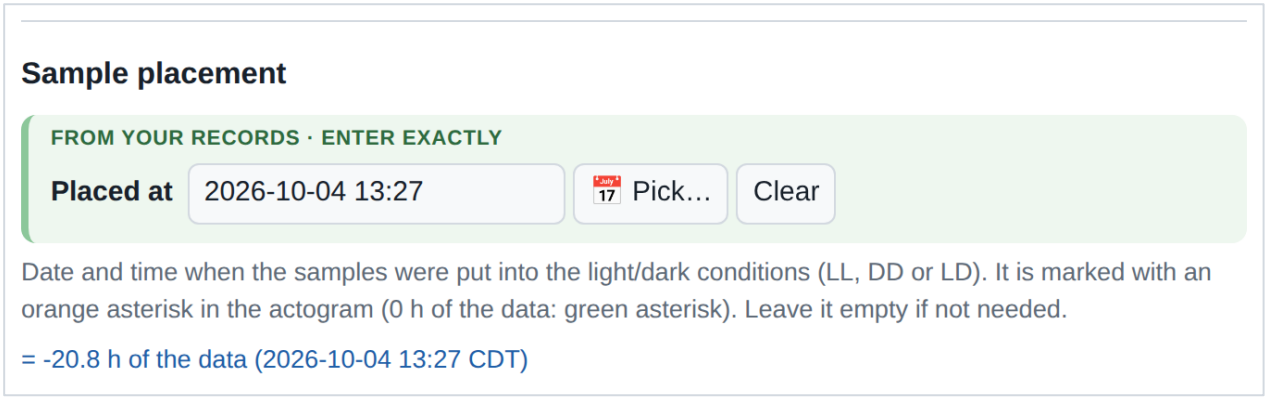
Clear data empties both lists (Ctrl+Z in a list brings them back).

Clear all also blanks the clock time of 0 h, the sample placement and every LD start date, and resets the cycles to LD 12:00 / 12:00 followed by LL: the starting point for a new experiment.



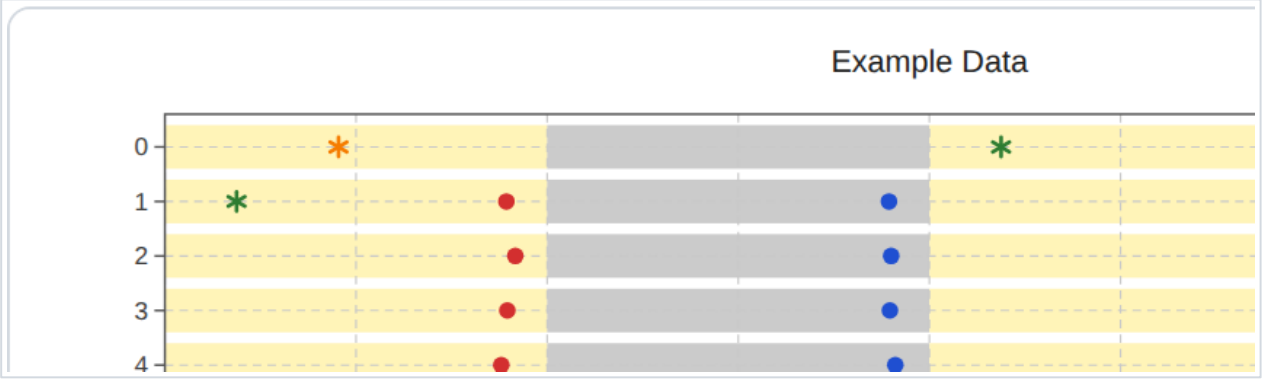
Each button asks first; No is preselected

3 Sample placement



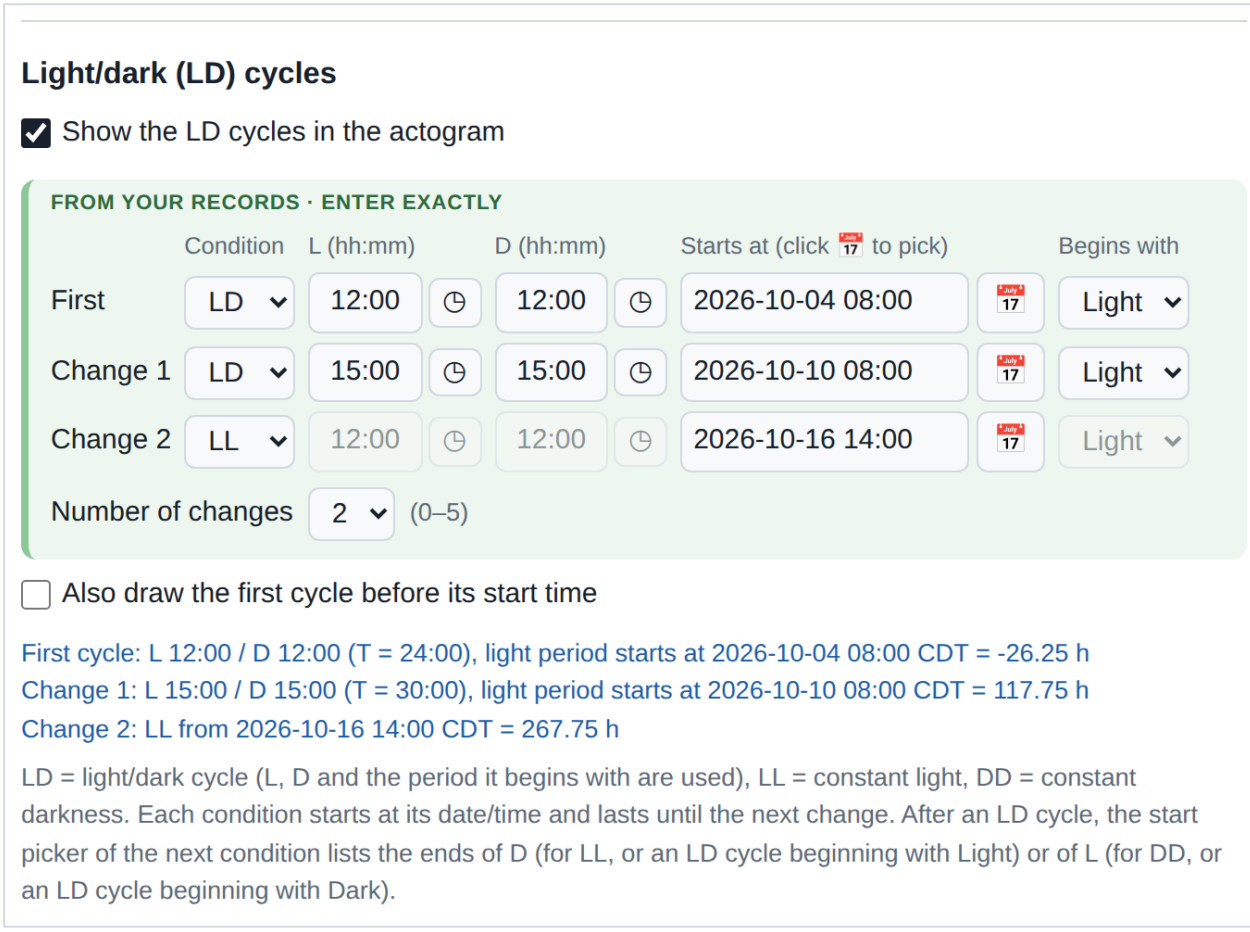
Placed at is the local date and time when the samples were put into the light/dark conditions (LL, DD or LD), for example when the culture dishes were set in the incubator. It is optional: leave it empty if you do not need it, and use **Clear** to empty it.

- The blue line under the field shows the same moment in hours of the data (for the example, −20.8 h: 20.8 hours before 0 h).
- In the actogram it is marked with an **orange asterisk**; 0 h of the data is marked with a **green asterisk**. In a double plot each asterisk also appears one row higher, at x + T.
- With Rows set to Automatic, the row that contains the placement is always shown.
- The placement also sets one of the choices for **Actogram day 0, 0 h**: 00:00 (midnight) on the day the sample was placed.
- Untick **Mark 0 h of the data … and the sample placement** under Plot to hide both asterisks, for example in a figure for publication.



*Example data: orange * = samples placed (4 Oct 13:27), green * = 0 h of the data (5 Oct 10:15)*

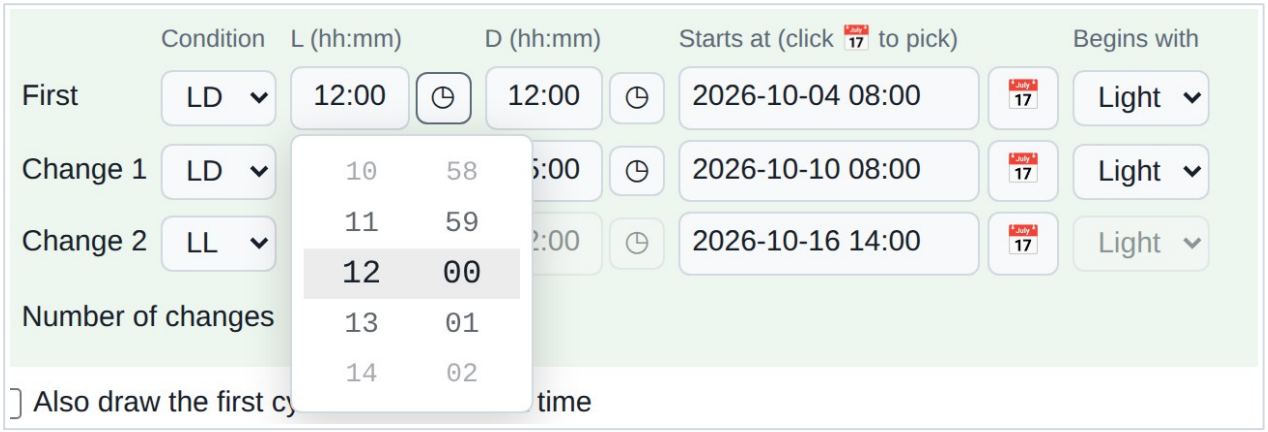
4 Light/dark (LD) cycles



Item	How to set it
Show the LD cycles	Tick to draw light periods (pale yellow) and dark periods (grey) behind the points.
Condition	LD = light/dark cycle, LL = constant light, DD = constant darkness.
L, D (hh:mm)	Lengths of the light and dark periods, 00:00–99:59 (default 12:00). Other T-cycles are possible: 15:00 + 15:00 gives T = 30 h. Type them or click ◷.
Starts at	Local date and time at which the condition begins (picker).
Begins with	Whether an LD cycle starts with its Light or its Dark period at that time.
Number of changes	0–5 changes after the first cycle. Each condition lasts until the next one starts.
Also draw the first cycle before its start time	Extends the first condition backwards, for example to show entrainment before recording started.

Blue lines under the table show when each condition starts, in hours of the data; red lines report errors.

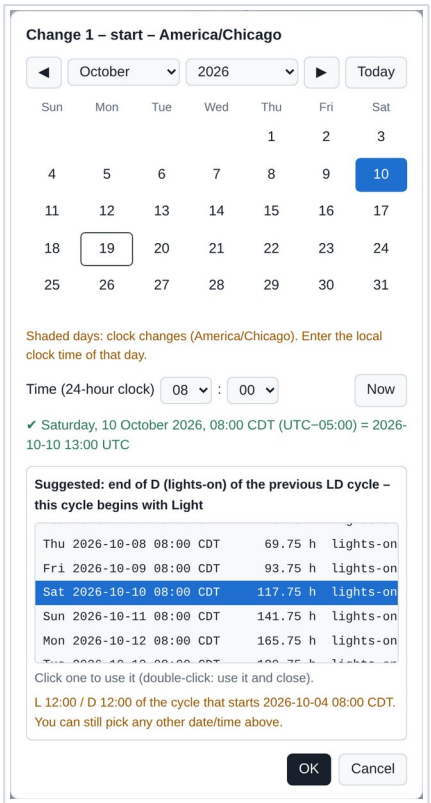
4 Lengths and condition changes



Picking L and D with the mouse. Click ◷ next to the field. Scroll the mouse wheel over the hours or the minutes column, drag a column up or down, or click a number; the value in the grey band is used and the plot follows at once. Arrow keys also work. Press Esc or Enter, or click elsewhere, to close.

Suggested start times. When the condition before a change is LD, the start picker of that change also lists when that LD cycle's D or L ends. Click one to use it, or double-click to use it and close; any other time can still be picked. Set Condition and Begins with first.

New condition	Suggested times
LL	End of D (lights-on)
DD	End of L (lights-off)
LD, begins with Light	End of D (lights-on)
LD, begins with Dark	End of L (lights-off)

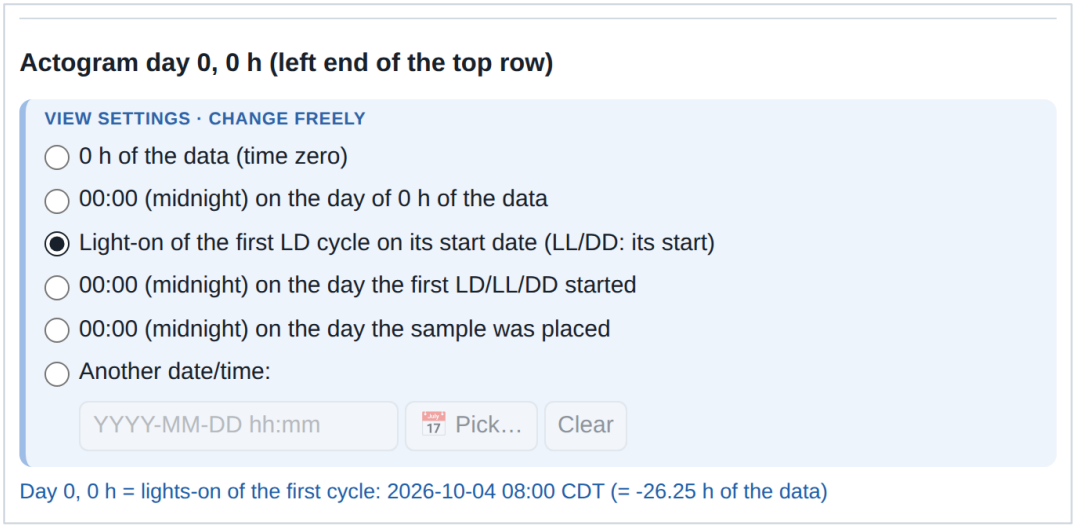


Change 1 (LD beginning with Light)

The schedule of the example data

	Condition	L / D	Starts at
First	LD	12:00 / 12:00	2026-10-04 08:00
Change 1	LD	15:00 / 15:00	2026-10-10 08:00
Change 2	LL	–	2026-10-16 14:00

5 Actogram day 0, 0 h



This sets the moment at the **left end of the top row** of the actogram. It is 0 h of the "Time within cycle" axis, and row n starts n × T later. It is a view setting: change it freely.

a **0 h of the data (time zero)**
Rows start at the clock time entered as 0 h.

b **00:00 (midnight) on the day of 0 h of the data**
Rows start at midnight of that day; the axis shows the time of day.

c **Light-on of the first LD cycle on its start date (LL/DD: its start)**
Rows start at lights-on, so the axis counts hours after lights-on (zeitgeber time). Recommended for most experiments.

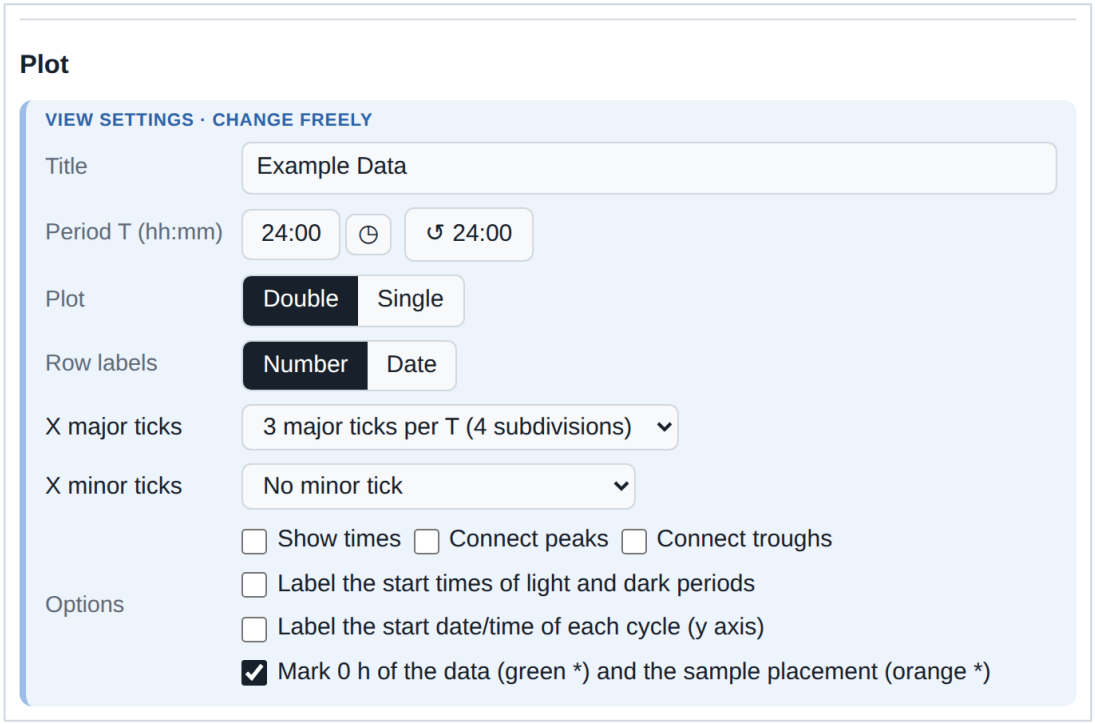
d **00:00 (midnight) on the day the first LD/LL/DD started**
Rows start at midnight of the day the lighting schedule began.

e **00:00 (midnight) on the day the sample was placed**
Rows start at midnight of the placement day (needs a sample placement time).

f **Another date/time**
Rows start at any date and time you pick. Clear empties the field.

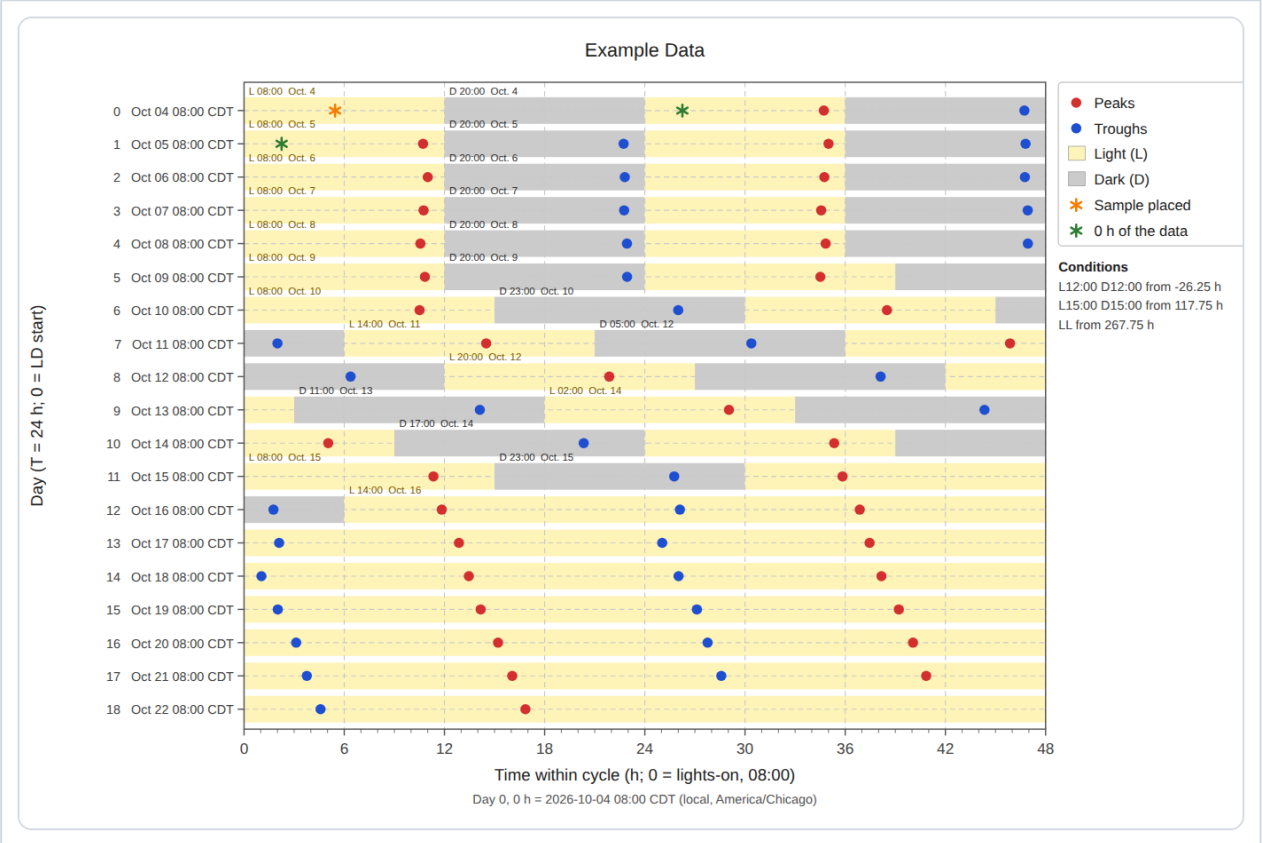
Good to know. The blue line under the options shows the chosen moment in hours of the data. If the chosen reference is missing (LD cycles hidden or with an error, no first start date, or no sample placement time), 0 h of the data is used and a note says so. Shifting day 0 in the fine-tune panel switches this to "Another date/time".

6 Plot settings



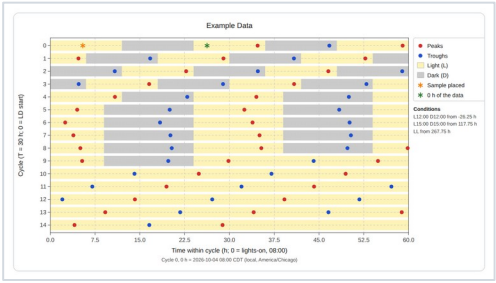
Setting	What it does
Title	Title above the figure. When empty, a description of the plot is used.
Period T (hh:mm)	Length of one row, 0:01–240:00 (default 24:00); type it or click ◷, and ↺ 24:00 sets it back to 24:00 in one click. A double plot spans 0 to 2T: with 30:00 the axis runs 0–60.
Plot	Double: each row shows two cycles (that row and the next). Single: one cycle per row.
Row labels	Row numbers, or the date on which each row starts.
X major ticks	0–5 labelled ticks within each period T (default 3, i.e. quarters of T).
X minor ticks	0–11 short unlabelled ticks between major ticks (default none).
Show times	Writes the time (h) next to each point.
Connect peaks / troughs	Joins each point to the one about one period later.
Label the start times of light and dark periods	Writes the local time and date of each lights-on and lights-off, e.g. “D 04:00 Oct. 6”.
Label the start date/time of each cycle	Adds each row’s start date and time to the vertical axis.
Mark 0 h of the data and the sample placement	Green asterisk at 0 h, orange asterisk at the sample placement (on by default).

7 Reading the actogram



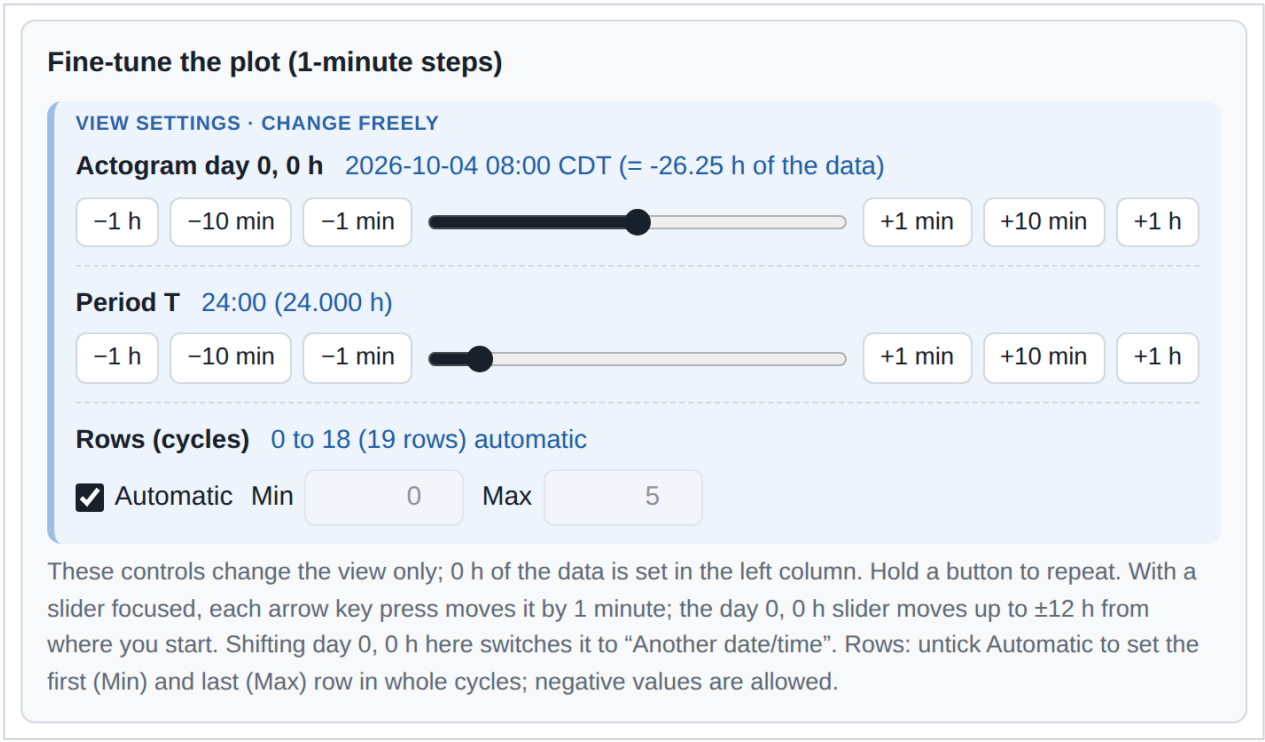
Example data with "Label the start times…", "Label the start date/time…" and 5 minor ticks

- **Rows** are successive cycles of length T, from day 0 downwards.
- **Double plot:** each row shows its own cycle and the next one, so every point appears twice (at x and, one row higher, at x + T).
- **Bands:** pale yellow = light, grey = dark, following the schedule.
- **Asterisks:** green = 0 h of the data, orange = sample placement.
- **Points:** red = peaks, blue = troughs. A rhythm locked to the cycle forms a vertical line; a free-running rhythm drifts to the right (period longer than T) or to the left (shorter).
- **Right side:** legend and the list of conditions with their start in hours. Under the x axis: the clock time of day 0, 0 h.



With Period T = 30:00 the LD 15:15 part of the example lines up, and the axis runs 0–60.

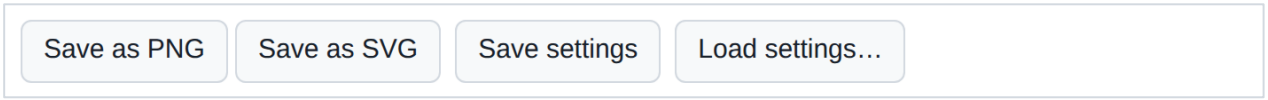
8 Fine-tuning the plot



Control	What it does
0 h of the data	Not in this panel: it is a recorded value, set only in the left column (Clock time of the data).
Actogram day 0, 0 h	Moves the left end of the rows. Using it switches day 0 to “Another date/time”.
Period T	Changes T between 0:01 and 240:00.
−1 h … +1 h buttons	Change the value by 1 min, 10 min or 1 h. Hold a button to repeat.
Sliders	Drag for a live change: up to ±12 h from where you start (day 0), or the full range of T. With a slider focused, each arrow key moves 1 minute.
Rows (cycles)	Automatic shows every row with data. Untick it to set the first (Min) and last (Max) row in whole cycles; negative numbers show cycles before day 0. At most 1000 rows are drawn.

Tip. For a free-running rhythm, drag the Period T slider until the peaks line up vertically: T is then close to the free-running period (about 24:48 for the LL part of the example).

9 Saving your work



PNG Save as PNG

A picture at three times the screen resolution, for slides, documents and posters. The file is named after the title.

SVG Save as SVG

A vector drawing that can be edited in Illustrator, Inkscape or PowerPoint (ungroup it after inserting).

{ } Save settings

All inputs and options in one JSON file: data, clock time, time zone, LD cycles and plot settings.

↑ Load settings...

Reopens a settings file. Files from the desktop version (Actogram_Plotter_app.py) open too, and vice versa.

What the browser remembers. The page keeps your display options in this browser between visits. Each visit starts again with the example data, period T = 24:00 and US Central Time, so use **Save settings** to keep your own data.

Privacy. Everything you enter stays in your browser. No data is uploaded or sent anywhere.

Troubleshooting

Message or problem	Cause and what to do
"... does not exist in America/Chicago (the clocks jump forward then)"	The time falls in the hour skipped when daylight time starts (March). Pick another time.
"... happens twice ... Choose the first or the second one"	The time falls in the hour repeated when daylight time ends (November). Choose CDT (first) or CST (second).
"Clock time of 0 h: pick a date and time."	The clock time of 0 h is empty (for example after Clear all). Pick it with Pick....
No asterisks	Tick "Mark 0 h of the data ... and the sample placement" under Plot; the orange one also needs a sample placement time.
"Not a number: ..." under a list	The list contains text, units or a decimal comma. Keep only numbers, with a decimal point.
"L and D must be between 00:00 and 99:59 ..."	An LD cycle has an invalid length, or L + D = 0. Correct L or D.
"... its start must be later than the start of the previous cycle"	The changes are not in time order. Correct the start dates and times.
"Period T must be between 0:01 and 240:00"	Enter T as hh:mm within that range.
No light/dark bands	Tick "Show the LD cycles", and fix any red message under the LD table.
Note: "The LD cycles are not valid yet, so 0 h of the data is used"	Day 0 is set to lights-on but the LD cycles have an error. Fix them, or choose another day 0 option.
Some points are missing	They lie outside the rows shown. Tick Rows → Automatic, or widen Min / Max (negative values are allowed).
"Only the first 1000 rows are drawn"	Period T is very short compared with the data. Use a longer T.
"Saving isn't available in this view"	Open the app from its web address (dxda6216.github.io/actogram_plotter) and save from there.